

Question:

A 60-year-old woman is brought to the emergency department because of altered mental status for 2 hours. She and her husband were at the grocery store when she suddenly could not remember why she was there or how she got there. She has not had any head trauma. She has a history of depression and migraines. She does not smoke and drinks a glass of wine each night with dinner. She takes fluoxetine daily. She appears distressed and anxious. Her vital signs are within normal limits. She is fully alert and oriented to self and place but not to time. Every few minutes she asks how she got to the emergency department. She is able to follow commands and sustain attention. She recalls 3/3 objects immediately and recalls 0/3 objects at 5 minutes. The remainder of the neurological exam shows no abnormalities. Which of the following is the most likely diagnosis?

Answer Choices:

- A. Transient global amnesia
- B. Depersonalization/derealization disorder
- C. Seizure
- D. Migraine

Reasoning + Answer:

<think>

To determine the most likely diagnosis, we need to analyze the symptoms and history provided. The patient has a sudden onset of altered mental status, specifically difficulty remembering the cause of her current situation and her surroundings, which is a key feature of transient global amnesia (TGA). TGA is characterized by sudden, temporary episodes of memory loss, typically lasting from a few minutes to a few hours, with full recovery of memory within 24 hours. The patient's ability to recall recent events and her surroundings is impaired, but she is fully alert and oriented to her identity and location. This pattern is consistent with TGA, especially given the lack of head trauma, normal vital signs, and absence of other neurological abnormalities.

Considering the patient's history of depression and migraines, it's possible that her condition could be related to a migraine or a seizure, but the transient nature of the symptoms and the lack of other neurological abnormalities make TGA the most likely diagnosis.

Depersonalization/derealization disorder involves a feeling of detachment from oneself or the world around, which is not a primary symptom in this case. A seizure could cause altered mental status, but it would likely involve other neurological abnormalities, which are not present in this patient.

Therefore, the most likely diagnosis is transient global amnesia, given the patient's sudden onset of memory loss and the absence of other neurological abnormalities.</think><answer> A. Transient global amnesia </answer>